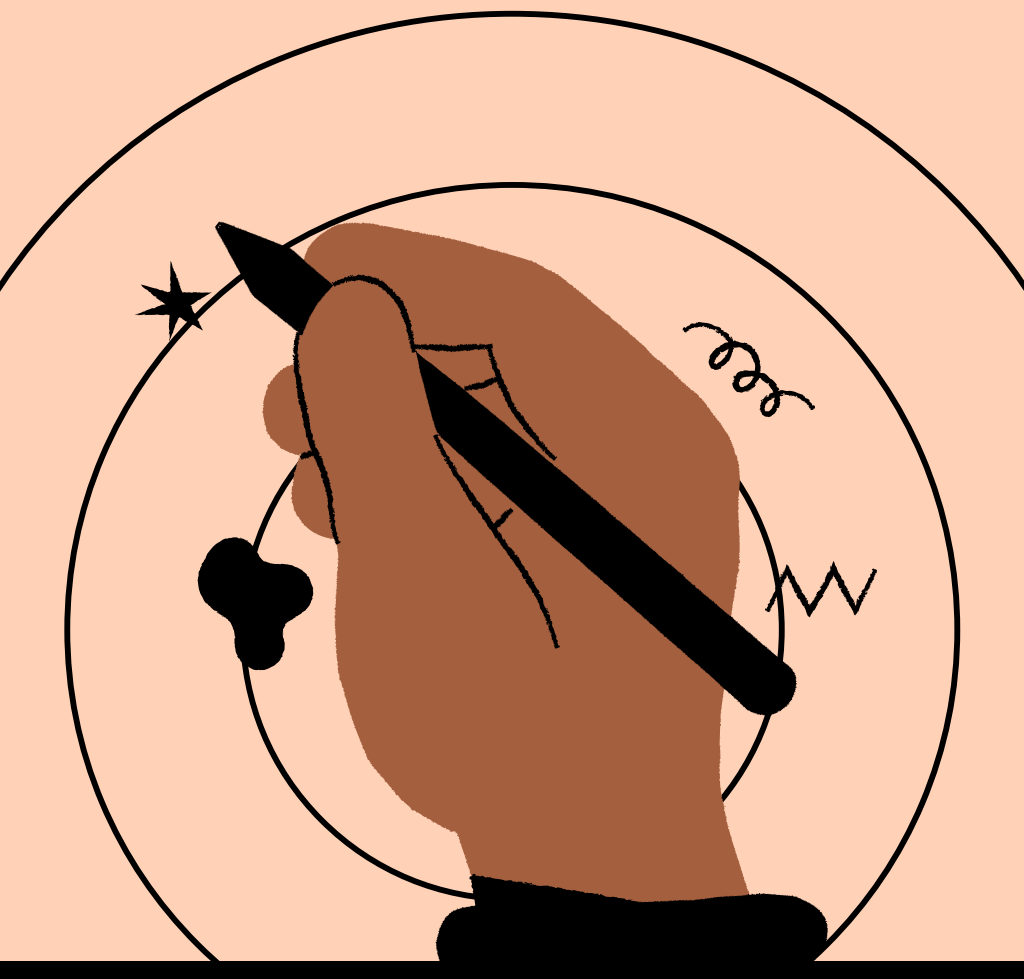


THE BLACK GIRL IN PHARMA

Career Pathway Playbook

By Sharon Agbonwaneten



CONTENTS

WELCOME TO BLACK GIRL IN PHARMA

HOW TO USE THIS PLAYBOOK

UNDERSTANDING THE PHARMACEUTICAL INDUSTRY

PHARMA CAREER PATHWAYS EXPLAINED

BREAKING INTO PHARMA: LANDING YOUR FIRST ROLE

THRIVING IN YOUR FIRST 0 - 3 YEARS

NAVIGATING PHARMA AS A BLACK WOMAN

CAREER GROWTH & LONG-TERM STRATEGY

TOOLS, RESOURCES & NEXT STEPS

FINAL WORDS: BUILDING A SUSTAINABLE CAREER

REFLECTION PROMPTS & CAREER CHECKPOINTS



INTRODUCTION

Welcome to Black Girl In Pharma

Dear reader,

This playbook was created for Black women who are at the beginning of their pharmaceutical careers or courageously finding their way into the industry and are searching for clarity, confidence, and direction.

Pharmaceuticals is a powerful, global field, yet it is surprisingly not widely known or clearly explained to students and early professionals. I created this guide to help bridge that gap and to make the path forward feel more accessible, informed, and possible.

I know this journey personally. As a Black woman building my own career in pharma, I have navigated uncertainty, imposter syndrome, and steep learning curves that often felt impossible to overcome. Through experience, continuous learning, and resilience, I discovered that success in this industry does not require perfection. It requires strategy, self-belief, and sustainability.

This playbook is not about having all the answers or following a rigid formula. It is about progress. It is about building a career that aligns with your ambition while protecting your well-being. It is about equipping you with the tools, perspective, and confidence to take up space, advocate for yourself, and grow with intention.

You belong here. And this guide is one of many steps toward helping you believe that too.

*Sharon
Agbonwaneten*

GET IN TOUCH

www.linkedin.com/in/sharon-agbonwaneten

<https://www.linkedin.com/company/blackgirlinpharma/>



How To Use This Playbook

This playbook is designed to be practical and actionable.

You can:

- Read it from start to finish
- Jump directly to the career pathway that interests you
- Return to sections as you move through your first few years

You do not need to have everything figured out. This playbook is here to help you ask better questions, make informed decisions, and move forward with intention.

Career Disclaimer: This playbook is meant to support and inform your career journey. It is for educational purposes only and is not a substitute for personalized career, legal, or professional advice. Every path is unique, and readers are encouraged to use their own judgment and seek additional guidance when making career decisions.



Understanding The Pharmaceutical Industry

The pharmaceutical industry includes companies and organizations involved in:

- Drug development
- Clinical research
- Manufacturing
- Regulatory submission and approval
- Quality and compliance
- Drug safety and monitoring

Pharma vs Biotech vs CDMO

- Pharma: Large, established companies that develop and commercialize drugs
- Biotech: Innovation-focused companies often working on novel therapies
- CDMO: Contract organizations that manufacture or test products for other companies

All three offer strong entry-level opportunities.

Types of Employment

- Permanent (full-time)
- Contract (3 to 18 months)
- Internship / co-op

Contract roles are common early in pharma and can be excellent career accelerators.



PHARMA CAREER PATHWAYS EXPLAINED

1. Quality Assurance (QA)
2. Regulatory Affairs (RA)
3. Clinical Research
4. Manufacturing & Operations
5. Pharmacovigilance / Drug Safety



1. Quality Assurance (QA)

What Does Quality Assurance (QA) Do?

Quality Assurance ensures that products meet required **quality, safety, and regulatory standards** before they reach patients or consumers. QA professionals are responsible for safeguarding compliance across the entire manufacturing process.

Their work includes:

- Inspecting products and processes to **identify and prevent defects**
- Performing **line clearances** to confirm equipment and areas are ready for production
- Reviewing and approving batch records, logbooks, and documentation
- **Auditing** work areas, procedures, and systems to ensure compliance with regulations and internal standards

In short, QA acts as the final checkpoint, making sure everything is **done right, documented correctly, and compliant** before a product moves forward.

Entry-Level Roles (0–1 year):

- QA Associate
- QA Technician
- Document Control Associate

Early Career Roles (1–3 years):

- QA Specialist
- Quality Systems Associate

Key Skills:

- Attention to detail
- SOP comprehension
- Documentation
- GMP knowledge

Career Progression: QA Associate → QA Specialist II → Senior QA → Senior QA Specialist → QA Manager → Site Quality Manager → Director of Quality



2. Regulatory Affairs (RA)

What Does Regulatory Affairs Do?

Regulatory Affairs ensures that products comply with **health authority laws, guidelines, and regulatory requirements** throughout their lifecycle.

Their responsibilities include:

- Preparing, compiling, and submitting **regulatory submissions** to health authorities for product approval
- **Interacting with regulatory agencies** and serving as the main point of contact
- Responding to health authority questions, requests, and deficiencies
- Ensuring **ongoing compliance** for approved products as regulations evolve

In essence, Regulatory Affairs acts as the **bridge between the company and health authorities**, guiding products safely and compliantly from development to market.

Entry-Level Roles (0–1 year):

- Regulatory Affairs Assistant
- Regulatory Coordinator

Early Career Roles (1–3 years):

- Regulatory Affairs Associate

Key Skills:

- Scientific writing
- Attention to detail
- Communication
- Regulatory guidelines

Career Progression: Regulatory Affairs Assistant → Regulatory Coordinator → Regulatory Affairs Associate → Senior Regulatory Affairs Associate → Regulatory Manager → Senior Regulatory Lead → Director of Regulatory Affairs



3. Clinical Research

What Does Clinical Research Do?

Clinical Research **manages and oversees clinical trials** to ensure they are conducted ethically, safely, and in compliance with regulations.

Their work includes:

- Designing and **coordinating clinical trials**
- Protecting participant safety and rights
- Ensuring accurate, reliable, and compliant **data collection**
- **Monitoring trial progress** and adherence to study protocols

Ultimately, Clinical Research helps generate **the scientific evidence needed to prove** a product's safety and effectiveness before it reaches the market.

Entry-Level Roles (0–1 year):

- Clinical Trial Assistant
- Study Coordinator

Early Career Roles (1–3 years):

- Clinical Research Associate (CRA)

Key Skills:

- Organization
- Communication
- Regulatory documentation

Career Progression: Clinical Trials Assistant → Clinical Research Associate (CRA) → Senior CRA → Clinical Project Manager



4. Manufacturing & Operations

What Does Manufacturing & Operations Do?

Manufacturing & Operations is responsible for **producing pharmaceutical products in controlled, regulated environments** to ensure consistency, quality, and safety.

Their responsibilities include:

- Operating and maintaining manufacturing equipment
- Following validated processes and **standard operating procedures (SOPs)**
- Ensuring products are made according to strict quality and regulatory standards
- **Supporting scale-up**, troubleshooting, and continuous process improvement

In short, Manufacturing & Operations turns **scientific formulas into real, high-quality products** ready for patients.

Entry-Level Roles (0–1 year):

- Manufacturing Technician
- Production Associate

Early Career Roles (1–3 years):

- Senior Technician
- Operations Associate

Key Skills:

- GMP compliance
- Process adherence
- Team collaboration

Career Progression: Manufacturing Technician → Senior Technician → Manufacturing Supervisor → Operations Manager → Director of Manufacturing



5. Pharmacovigilance / Drug Safety

What Does Pharmacovigilance / Drug Safety Do?

Pharmacovigilance (Drug Safety) is responsible for **monitoring, assessing, and preventing adverse effects** associated with pharmaceutical products to protect patient safety.

Their work includes:

- Collecting and evaluating adverse event reports
- **Detecting safety signals** and potential risks
- Reporting safety information to health authorities
- Ensuring **ongoing benefit–risk assessment** after product approval

Ultimately, Pharmacovigilance ensures that **medicines remain safe and effective** for patients throughout their lifecycle.

Entry-Level Roles (0–1 year):

- Drug Safety Associate

Early Career Roles (1–3 years):

- Pharmacovigilance Specialist

Key Skills:

- Medical terminology
- Data analysis
- Attention to detail

Career Progression: Drug Safety Associate → Pharmacovigilance Specialist → Safety Manager → Director of Pharmacovigilance

Breaking Into Pharma: Landing Your First Role



Resume Strategy

Your resume should clearly show how your experience aligns with each specific role you apply for. A targeted resume stands out far more than a generic one.

- Tailor your resume to every role by emphasizing the skills and experiences most relevant to that position
- Use keywords from the job description to improve applicant tracking system (ATS) matching and recruiter visibility
- Highlight compliance, documentation, and cross-functional collaboration
- Quantify your impact where possible
- Use AI tools strategically to refine bullet points, identify missing keywords, and improve clarity, while ensuring the content remains accurate and authentic to your experience

LinkedIn Strategy

LinkedIn is more than a job board, it's a visibility and credibility platform.

- Optimize your headline to clearly state your role, career focus, and industry (e.g., "Quality Assurance Associate | GMP & Compliance | Biopharma")
- Share your learning journey, including certifications, courses, projects, or lessons from work experiences
- Engage with industry professionals by commenting thoughtfully on posts, reposting insights, and contributing value
- Check LinkedIn job postings 2–3 times per week, especially on Tuesday, Wednesday, and Thursday, when recruiter activity is typically highest
- Turn on job alerts for roles and companies you're targeting to stay ahead

Networking Strategy

Strong networks are built through genuine curiosity and consistent follow-up, not transactional asks.

- Ask thoughtful questions, not favors, focusing on learning about roles, career paths, and industry trends
- Be curious, respectful, and prepared
- Follow up professionally with a thank-you message or a short note reflecting what you learned
- Attend industry events, conferences, and webinars to gain insight, expand your network, and stay current with industry developments
- Maintain relationships over time by checking in periodically and sharing relevant updates or resources

Together, these strategies help you build a strong professional brand, increase visibility, and create consistent career momentum in the pharmaceutical and life sciences industry.



Thriving in Your First 0–3 Years

Your Early Years Are About Learning — Not Proving Perfection

The early stage of your career is a foundation-building phase, not a performance of flawlessness. Growth comes from curiosity, consistency, and the ability to learn quickly, not from pretending to know everything.

Key Principles to Guide Your Early Career:

Ask Questions Early and Often

Asking questions shows engagement, not weakness. Clarifying expectations, processes, and priorities early helps prevent errors and builds trust. It's far better to ask once than to correct something later.

Learn SOPs Thoroughly

Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) are the backbone of regulated industries. Take time to understand not just what the procedure says, but why it exists. This builds confidence, improves compliance, and strengthens decision-making.

Accept Feedback with Professionalism

Feedback is not a personal attack—it's a growth tool. Listen actively, avoid defensiveness, and apply what you learn. Managers value professionals who can take feedback, adjust, and improve.

Document Your Achievements and Learning

Keep a running record of:

- Tasks you've completed
- Systems, processes, and regulations you've learned
- Projects you've contributed to
- Problems you've helped solve

This makes performance reviews and manager check-ins more productive and ensures your contributions don't go unnoticed.

Use Manager Check-Ins Strategically

Refer back to your documented progress during one-on-ones. Share what you've learned, where you're gaining confidence, and what support you may need next. This shows ownership of your development.

A Final Reminder

Mistakes will happen and that's normal. What truly matters is accountability, reflection, and growth. Own your errors, learn from them, and move forward stronger. That's how careers are built.



Navigating Pharma as a Black Woman

In professional environments, especially in science, pharma, and corporate settings, you may face challenges that are rarely talked about but deeply felt.

You may:

- Be the **only Black woman** in the room
- Feel constant pressure to overperform to be taken seriously
- **Question whether you truly belong**
- Experience imposter syndrome, even when you are qualified
- Feel **uncomfortable** showing up as your full, authentic self

These experiences are real, valid, and shared by many, yet they do not define your worth or capability.

Strategies to Protect Yourself and Thrive

Separate Confidence from Comparison

Your confidence should come from your skills, growth, and effort—not from comparing yourself to others. Everyone’s path, pace, and starting point are different. Focus on your own progress.

Set and Maintain Professional Boundaries

You do not need to overextend yourself to prove value. Protect your time, energy, and emotional capacity. Boundaries are not barriers—they are tools for longevity and respect.

Seek Mentors and Allies

Find people who advocate for you, offer honest guidance, and understand the systems you’re navigating. Mentors don’t all have to look like you, but they must support your growth and voice.

Protect Your Mental Health

High-performance environments can be draining. Prioritize rest, reflection, and support systems outside of work. Your well-being is not optional—it’s essential.

Do Not Take Everything Personally

Not every comment, silence, or decision is about you. Learn to separate feedback from identity and situations from self-worth. Discern what deserves your energy and what does not.

Final Truth

Representation matters but so does sustainability.

Your goal is not just to be present in the room, but to remain healthy, whole, and thriving while you’re there.

Career Growth & Long-Term Strategy ↑

Knowing When It's Time to Move On

Career growth is not just about staying, it's about recognizing when a role has taught you what it can and it's time for your next chapter.

You may consider moving on:

- After a period of consistent learning, when you've mastered your responsibilities and **no longer feel challenged**
- When **growth plateaus** and opportunities to expand your skills, responsibilities, or exposure are limited
- When alignment is lost, whether with leadership, values, or long-term career goals
- If the environment **does not support learning, mentorship, or effective communication**, making growth difficult or unsustainable

Certifications That Strengthen Your Profile

Certifications help formalize your experience, close skill gaps, and signal readiness for the next level.

- **GMP Training** to strengthen understanding of regulated manufacturing environments
- **Regulatory or Clinical Certifications** aligned with your target career path
- **RAPS RAC Certification** for those pursuing regulatory affairs leadership and long-term credibility

Thinking Long-Term About Your Career

Early career decisions should always ladder up to a bigger picture.

- Focus on transferable skills such as documentation, compliance, risk assessment, project coordination, and cross-functional collaboration
- Build relationships, not just resumes—people open doors more often than job titles
- Be intentional about your future: visualize where you want to be in 3, 5, or 10 years, then work backward to identify the roles, skills, and experiences needed to get there

A successful career is not accidental. It's built through clarity, strategy, and timing.



Tools, Resources & Next Steps

These next few pages are designed to give you practical tools you can return to throughout your 0–3 year journey in pharma. These resources are not about doing everything at once, but about building strong habits and systems early.

1. **Resume checklist (Pharma-Focused)**
2. **LinkedIn profile checklist**
3. **Interview preparation guide**
4. **Learning & Skill-Building Resources**



1. Resume Checklist

Before submitting your application, review your resume with intention. A strong pharma resume is not just a work history. It is a proof of how you operate in regulated environments.

1. Clearly define your experience

- List your job title, company name, and employment dates clearly
- Use consistent formatting so recruiters can scan quickly

2. Highlight regulated-industry experience

- Explicitly reference GMP, SOPs, compliance, documentation, and audits
- Show exposure to cross-functional collaboration (QA, Manufacturing, Regulatory, Clinical)

3. Use strong, outcome-focused action verbs

- Focus on what you did and how it contributed to quality, compliance, or efficiency

4. Quantify your impact whenever possible

- Numbers strengthen credibility
- If exact numbers are unavailable, use estimates responsibly

5. Tailor your resume for every role

- Mirror keywords from the job description to improve ATS compatibility
- Adjust bullets to reflect the priority skills of each role

6. Use AI strategically

- Use AI tools to:
 - Refine bullet points
 - Improve clarity and structure
 - Identify missing keywords
- Always review and personalize the output to ensure accuracy and authenticity

Your resume should communicate how you think, how you work, and how you add value — not just where you have been.

🌟 Want a head start?

Check out my downloadable Pharma Resume Template, designed specifically for early-career professionals in Quality, Regulatory, Clinical, and Manufacturing roles.



2. LinkedIn Profile Checklist

Optimize Your LinkedIn Profile

Your LinkedIn profile is often reviewed before your resume and, in many cases, serves as your first professional impression. Recruiters and hiring managers use LinkedIn to quickly assess your background, credibility, and alignment with pharmaceutical roles.

To position yourself strongly, ensure your profile includes the following:

1. A clear and targeted headline

Your headline should immediately communicate your current role or career focus, the industry you are in or pursuing, and your area of interest. This helps recruiters understand where you fit within pharma at a glance.

2. A concise, intentional summary

Use your summary to explain who you are, your background, and where you are headed. Highlight your interest in pharmaceuticals, quality, regulatory, clinical, or related fields, and briefly outline your career goals. This section should sound confident, professional, and purposeful.

3. Relevant experience with measurable outcomes

List experiences that demonstrate transferable skills, even if they are academic, internship, or volunteer-based. Where possible, include measurable results such as improved processes, supported audits, reviewed documentation, or compliance-related contributions.

4. Skills aligned with pharmaceutical roles

Include skills that are commonly sought in pharma, such as GMP, Quality Assurance, Regulatory Affairs, Clinical Operations, documentation control, and data integrity. These keywords improve search visibility and alignment with job postings.

5. A professional, credible photo

Your profile photo should be clear, well-lit, and professional. Choose a neutral background and attire that reflects confidence and credibility within a regulated industry.

6. Stay Active and Visible

Engagement matters. Aim to engage on LinkedIn at least once a week by liking, commenting on, or sharing content related to pharmaceuticals, biotechnology, quality, regulatory affairs, or STEM. Consistent engagement increases visibility, builds professional relationships, and signals genuine interest in the industry.

3. Interview Preparation Guide

Strong interview performance in the pharmaceutical industry comes from preparation, not memorization. Before any interview, take time to build a clear understanding of both the company and the role.

Research the company and its products

Learn what the company manufactures or develops, whether it is pharmaceuticals, biologics, vaccines, or medical devices. Understand their product pipeline, target therapeutic areas, and where the role fits within the organization. This shows genuine interest and helps you tailor your answers.

Study the job description line by line

Review each responsibility and qualification carefully. Identify where your experience aligns, even if that experience comes from school, internships, co-ops, labs, or volunteer work. Be prepared to explain how your skills translate to the role.

Prepare structured examples using the STAR method

Use the STAR method to organize your responses: describe the Situation, Task, Action, and Result. This approach helps you answer clearly, stay focused, and demonstrate impact, even for early-career experiences.

Common Early-Career Pharma Interview Questions

Many pharmaceutical interviews focus on quality, compliance, and professional judgment. Common questions include:

- Tell me about a time you followed an SOP or standard procedure
- How do you handle mistakes, errors, or deviations?
- How do you manage documentation, accuracy, and deadlines?
- Why are you interested in this role and this company?

These questions are designed to assess your attention to detail, accountability, and understanding of working in a regulated environment.

Practice Clear and Confident Communication

Practice explaining your experience in a way that is calm, honest, and easy to understand. Avoid rushing or over-explaining. It is okay to pause, think, and respond thoughtfully. Confidence in pharma interviews comes from clarity, professionalism, and demonstrating a willingness to learn.



4. Learning & Skill-Building Resources

Focus on Transferable Skills

In the pharmaceutical industry, the most valuable skills are those that transfer across roles, departments, and companies. Building a strong foundation early allows you to pivot within QA, Regulatory, Clinical, or Compliance as your career evolves.

Key transferable skills to prioritize include:

GMP fundamentals

Develop a solid understanding of Good Manufacturing Practices, including data integrity, controlled documentation, change control, deviations, and CAPA. These principles apply across manufacturing, quality, regulatory, and clinical environments.

Documentation best practices

Accuracy, clarity, and traceability are critical in pharma. Learn how to write, review, and maintain documentation in a way that is compliant, clear, and inspection-ready. Strong documentation skills are universally valued and highly transferable.

Regulatory and compliance basics

Gain familiarity with regulatory frameworks and expectations, such as inspection readiness, regulatory submissions, and audit processes. Understanding how compliance supports patient safety and product quality strengthens your professional judgment.

Communication and stakeholder management

Pharma is highly cross-functional. Learn how to communicate clearly with manufacturing, quality, regulatory, clinical, and leadership teams. Being able to explain quality or compliance requirements respectfully and confidently is a key differentiator.

Learning Platforms to Explore

You do not need expensive programs to grow. Many effective learning opportunities are accessible and practical:

- Company-provided training portals and internal SOP training
- Free or low-cost online courses focused on GMP, quality systems, or regulatory basics
- Industry webinars, conferences, and professional networking events

Choose learning opportunities that reinforce your current role while building skills for your next one.

A Sustainable Approach to Growth

Consistency matters more than volume. Small, steady learning efforts build confidence and competence over time. Focus on continuous improvement rather than trying to learn everything at once. Sustainable growth is what leads to long-term success in the pharmaceutical industry.



Final Words: Building a Sustainable Career

Early career success is easier with structure.

Consider:

- Keeping a career journal to track accomplishments
- Saving positive feedback and performance highlights
- Reviewing your goals every 6 months
- Identifying skills you want to build each year

This helps you prepare for performance reviews and future roles.

Your career does not need to be rushed to be successful.

You are allowed to rest, recalibrate, and redefine success on your terms.

This playbook is not the end, it is a starting point.

Welcome to your **#BlackGirlInPharma** journey.

You belong here.

Next Steps: How to Use This Playbook Going Forward

1. Identify the pathway that interests you most
2. Compare your current skills to role expectations
3. Create a 6–12 month learning and growth plan
4. Apply intentionally, not randomly
5. Revisit this playbook as your confidence and experience grow

Your early career is about exploration, not perfection.



Reflection Prompts & Career Checkpoints

Use these prompts at the end of each quarter or role transition to stay aligned and intentional.

Career Clarity

- Which pharma pathway currently interests me the most, and why?
- What skills do I enjoy building the most in my role?
- What parts of my work give me energy versus drain it?

Skill Development

- What new skills have I developed in the past 3–6 months?
- Which skills do I need to strengthen for my next role?
- How am I documenting my accomplishments?

Confidence & Growth

- Where have I grown professionally since my last reflection?
- What feedback have I received, and how can I use it constructively?
- How am I advocating for myself at work?

Sustainability

- Am I maintaining healthy boundaries?
- What does balance look like for me in this season?
- What support or mentorship do I need right now?

Return to these prompts regularly to guide your decisions with clarity and confidence.

**THANK YOU AND
BEST OF LUCK!**

*Sharon
Agbonwaneten*

[www.linkedin.com/in/sharon-
agbonwaneten](https://www.linkedin.com/in/sharon-agbonwaneten)

[https://www.linkedin.com/company/blac
kgirlinpharma/](https://www.linkedin.com/company/blackgirlinpharma/)